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RAMBLES ROUND VICTORIA

OUR SCENERY AND ITS HISTORY

By ROBERT CONNELL

III.

The Jordan River Country

On a misty morning in July, 1921, a brother geologist and I left Kirby Creek for Jordan River. The fine vapor blotted out the distant landscape entirely, but now and then the dark spires of hemlock and cedar rose above the gray veil and faintly suggested the nearby ridges. But as we approached French's Bay the blue sky began to emerge, and when Point No Point was approached, we were able to see it jutting out against the western waves. When the road had brought us above and opposite it, we found ourselves looking across a stretch of cleared land with a small cottage where the occupier lives alone and miles from neighbors. The clearing slopes to the sea cliffs and has become covered with a dense growth of salal and blackberries. Beyond it we looked seaward, where the whitecaps were racing before the breeze and breaking in showers of snowy spray over Point No Point. In the distance the lifted fog revealed the blue summits of the western Olympics. Clallam Peninsula stood out like an island. At the extremity we knew Cape Flattery to lie, and between it and the steep slopes of the most distant range of our own island lay some twenty miles of the Pacific Ocean. To look out on that unbounded horizon is to recall the whole tale of mystery and adventure which has marked pre-eminently our Western sea. Chiefly there came to one's mind that ancient mariner, Apostolos Valerianos, who in 1592 sailed for twenty days up the Straits that bear his better known name of Juan de Fuca. What the thought of the Greek pilot may have been, who can tell? Two hundred years later Captain George Vancouver passed inwards on H.M.S. Discovery, accompanied by H.M.S. Chatham. He had been a midshipman under Captain Cook when the great seaman made his voyage along the northwest coast of North America, and had participated in the unfortunate failure to locate the entrance of the Straits. So that on April 30, 1792, he must have experienced a keen satisfaction as he turned his two vessels eastward along the northern coast of the present State of Washington.

Sandstone Creek

So much for our historical and imaginative reflections. The road called us on. We crossed several small streams, almost dry in July, with rugged boulder-strewn beds, ending in precipitous plunges over the cliffs into the sea below. Some two miles beyond Point No Point a little pathway diverged from the road, and we followed it through a dense growth of salal, salmonberry, thimbleberry, and bracken. From the top of a sharp descent we found ourselves looking down into a secluded rockbound bay with a couple of cabins. Curiosity carried us on until at the foot of the slope we saw a little crystal stream plunge down an opening in the thicket. We clambered and slid down and after an almost vertical descent of twenty feet we stood on the beach below. Basaltic rocks cut by precipitous fissures bounded the little bay on the West. To the left a great angular block of basalt, twenty-five feet high and thirty-five feet in breadth stood between tides embedded in the old tertiary sandstone into which it had fallen from the ancient cliffs when the sands were young and plastic. About its base among the old cobblestones which shared its stormy bed were pieces of petrified wood from the forests of those days. Passing it to the East we discovered a line of well-exposed sandstone cliff, worn and excavated into irregular table-like forms. In these fossils were abundant, and it was not long before we had extracted from their resting-place some new contributions to the fauna of the tertiary period. Rounding a corner we found ourselves in a long wave-worn gallery resembling in some ways the celebrated Malaspino Gallery on the east coast. The height was about ten feet, and the backward extension about fifteen. Below the varying resistance of the rock had given rise to round or oval masses which stood a few inches or so above the main floor like footstools. Everywhere below, above, and in the wall were fossils, amongst which large but, unfortunately, fragile pectens or scallops were conspicuous. Beyond the gallery a mass of sandstone ran out at right angles to the cliff and with two breaks in its vertical walls, extended to a distance of about 120 feet, with an elevation on the landward side of thirty feet, from which, by a series of steps, it descended finally to a height of five feet. Beyond this lay some curious gullies and caves which the high tide prevented us from examining. Meanwhile from the fact that this rocky projection is the favorite resting-place of a bald-headed eagle we called it Eagle's Point.

No. 1 Camp, Jordan River

After a hasty lunch and an accompanying survey and sorting of our fossils we regained the high road and pressed on. A few hundred yards further we crossed the bridge on Sandstone Creek, whose clean and well-scoured bed was traversed by a Summer streamlet fed by the two branches which unite just above the bridge. Such, however, was our keenness to get to our destination that we paid little attention to the creek. Through towering hemlock and spruce the road wound steadily on. At length, through an opening, we caught a glimpse of a conspicuous rock mass, of which half is almost snow-white. It seemed but a short distance away, but in reality was some two miles off. The local name, well-descriptive of its appearance, is White Rock. At last we passed out of the forest and the open burnt-off lands about and above Jordan River lay before us. Soon the road turned upward along a deep claybanked gulch, and at its head were signposts which directed the traveler to the saw-mill, the Sunlock Mines, and the Vancouver Island Power Co.'s dams. A sharp swing to the left leads down to the village at the mouth of Jordan River, commonly known as No. 1 Camp. Here is the powerhouse, with its reverberating machinery situated against a background of trees and pouring forth the captured waters of Jordan River, whose energy has been in part taken for the purposes of the B.C. Electric Co., but that it is only in part is witnessed to by the mighty swirl of issuing flood. The village is a large assemblage of buildings, of which, however, only a fraction are now in use: the remainder have stood empty since construction days. Great elevated wharves extend into the waters, gaunt skeletons telling of the old activities when all the material of the power-house, the trolley line, and the great dam at No. 5 Camp were landed here. We spent but a short time at the village, and then decided on the bold stroke of making our return journey by the sea-shore, at least so far as tide and rock permitted. It was a charming walk of a little under two miles to our first and insurmountable difficulty. A protruding cliff of black basalt barred our way. We tried to get round the seaward side, but depth of water made it impossible, especially with the roll of the Pacific breakers, which had accompanied us all along the shore. Next we essayed the overland route, and succeeded in getting almost to the top when the dense growth of wind-pruned spruce and salal proved too much for us. So back we went along the foot of 200 yards of fossiliferous sandstone cliff, rising to a height of twenty-seven feet, till we reached a small waterfall fifteen feet high, with a delightful pool in the shingle below. Climbing up the stairway of irregularly weathered bands we found ourselves—on the bed of Sandstone Creek, a hundred yards or so below the bridge. The road was speedily taken and evening saw us once more beneath the alders at Kirby Creek.

Agricultural Lands and Possibilities

Since then I have had several visits to the cleared lands about the mouth and lower reaches of Jordan River. Last Summer I made two traverses, one with my former companion and one alone. I have been astonished that no use has yet been made of the possibilities of this district. About ten years ago the sloping hillsides were visited by a devastating fire which destroyed most of the light railway plant of the logging industry. Further, it swept away the remaining timber and left the countryside an apparent wilderness. This timber consisted of hemlock and spruce, with some cedar, and as a consequence the great charred logs and stumps which still dot the district and make traveling difficult in places on account of the size of the fallen timber are for the most part in a very advanced state of decay. Most of the logs are quite evidently rotten through and through. Practically no second-growth timber is to be found. The exception is a narrow belt along the remains of the old railway encircling White Rocks. It is only a few yards wide and consists largely of pine. The soil is a sandy loam, evidently of good quality to support so large a stand of timber, and is at present partly covered, but only partly, with a growth of coarse grasses, blackberries, and fireweed. It is very rarely that land can be seen here which is in so great a condition of preparedness for the settler as this. The slope is fairly steep in places, but I have seen as great on the rolling prairies. Several small streams, with a good flow of water even in mid-July, occupy steep valleys which they have cut through the glacial deposits and in their lower reaches through the sandstones too. The climate is wetter than in the Victoria district. In addition to the Winter rains there is what we often desire at the southern extremity of the Island, a Summer precipitation as well. The winds from the Pacific blow in laden with white mist, which discharges itself upon the land in welcome moisture. As a result there is a Summer greenness which is quite marked. Wild fruit, such as the salmonberry and the red and blue huckleberries grow to large size and are very abundant everywhere. I should imagine it would be a capital place for the growing of the real old-fashioned gooseberry, both red and amber. There is, too, a splendid outlook here for the sheep-raising industry. The scenery reminds one of the west of Scotland. The serrated lower Olympics of the west are like Arran from the Ayrshire Coast, with the distant prospect across the Mull of Kintyre. In July the pink of the fireweed, which may be seen fifteen miles away on the Clallam Peninsula, is at least reminiscent of heather. Here, too, are the same moisture-laden west winds which, though less in quantity, bring freshness and fertility to the slopes. From what I saw I should say there are 2,000 acres of land in the district ready for settlement. How these acres would have rejoiced the hearts of the Highland crofters who recently came to Red Deer! Good land, good fishing, and the scenery that the Gael loves! Transportation has been and is still the chief difficulty. But already work is proceeding on the new Kirby Creek grade, and with its completion one of the worst of hills will pass into tradition. The road requires, throughout its length from West Rocks, widening and in some cases straightening. The surface needs attention. What was good enough for horse-traffic will not do in these days of motor vehicles. When the road is made decently good to Jordan River we shall see a wave of settlement along this southwest coast. And if I am not much mistaken when tourists learn the beauty of the true Pacific Highway with its vistas of ocean and mountain and the crash of the breakers on the shingle beaches, they will make it seem wise and needful to have a road all round the coast to Alberni by Port Renfrew, Clo-oose, Banfield, and Sarita. About which time Vancouver Island will be beginning to come into its own.

FOUNDER CAME HERE IN DAYS OF GOLD RUSH

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Government Street was destined no longer to be the main retail business thoroughfare, while Yates, Broad and Douglas Streets came into prominence, forming the busy retail section.

During the fire and the period of preparing to resume business, not one of the firm's employees lost a day's employment. This was fully appreciated and all helped loyally in every way, using hammer and saw, when they could, in order to expediate the work of reconstruction. From that time till the present improvements have been made and now the firm has one of the most complete and convenient department stores in the West.

MADE RECORD PURCHASE FROM TORONTO HOUSE

In the early days, all freights for the West Coast came from England and were from four to six months on the way. The opening of the Canadian Pacific Railway, however in

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